

12. 'The digital age has handicapped the elderly.' Is this true?

Key Words

Digital age

Otherwise referred to as the Information Age, a historic period in the 21st century characterised by the **rapid shift** from traditional industry that the Industrial Revolution brought through industrialization, **to an economy based on information technology.**

It is the time period where **the use of digital technology became prevalent and of common use throughout the world**, evident in the many **social, economic and political activities that are dependent on information and communication technologies.**

The digital age is characterised by **rapid speed of technological development and the incessant technological change.**

The elderly

A consideration of some **traits** of the elderly that **may affect their ability to adopt digital technologies and function well in the digital age.** These may include education levels, language barriers, digital proficiency, physical challenges (more specifically hearing and eyesight). **It is not right and too sweeping to assume attitudes of the elderly as being unwilling to learn, or not adaptable to changes.**

Has handicapped

To be **disadvantaged** as a result of **barriers and difficulties brought about by the digital age where many of the everyday services have moved online.** They have **difficulty adopting digital technology** and are **unable to adapt well to function normally or keep abreast with the developments and demands** in the digital age. The elderly are often left out of public information and are not in the loop on vital updates of policies and changes. They are also unable to access digital services that are essential for everyday living e.g. only digital payments accepted for transactions.

The question requires a consideration of **the extent of the impact** of the digital age on the elderly. There may be a discussion of how **the diverse profiles within the group of elderly** (socio-economic status, educational level, having access to the internet, tech-savviness, etc) and **the different amount of support** can affect the elderly's ability to leverage on digital technology and benefit from it.

Stand

While it is true that the digital age has handicapped many seniors, digital technologies can offer many potential benefits if the elderly are able to embrace such technologies as a core part of everyday life and to continuously adapt to and integrate new digital technologies into daily routines and living environments.

Possible Approach

A) Arguments in favour of the statement

- The elderly **may lack the ability to learn as quickly and comprehensively as the digital natives**, and are **more likely to be digitally excluded and to experience barriers** accessing goods and services that are increasingly provided online.
 - As the elderly were not born into the digital world, they would have little understanding of the digital world and can be out of touch with the rapid changes, *especially if they have lower digital literacy and are not adept at learning new technological skills.*
 - For example, navigating the tech industry's abysmal use of jargon and the demand for constant updates *baffle the elderly with lower digital literacy and cause them to flounder* when they have to switch suddenly to using an app or a website to conduct their daily activities such as parking their car, checking their bank balance and making transactions.
 - Additionally, the need to keep up with the incessant demand for online passwords and to change their passwords frequently *can be a source of anxiety and stress, and increases their vulnerability to scams and exploitation if they lack awareness of cybersecurity or fail to adopt good cyber hygiene practices.* For example, the growing trend of smartphone and internet use among older Singaporeans coincides with an increase in cyber predation targeting the elderly as they are perceived to have more wealth or a larger 'nest egg'.
 - This is evident in the number of phishing scams involving seniors that have more than tripled from 153 in 2020 to 561 in 2021. In 2021, there were 207 cases of investment scams involving seniors, a 77 per cent increase from 117 in 2020.
 - Beyond daily inconveniences and heightened risks of scams and exploitation, digital exclusion of the elderly can escalate into a societal crisis, clearly evident in China during the COVID-19 outbreak in 2020. As access to services and health information played a critical role in crisis management during the pandemic, older people in China, *who do not have intelligent devices or are not IT savvy, cannot access the Internet, download apps or obtain the required information*, are at a loss in the face of complex operating procedures related to the pandemic. In the absence of information, these elderly face great disruptions to their daily life during the crisis and are not able to fully enjoy the digital solutions brought about by digital and intelligent services, such as cloud medical treatment, online entertainment and online consumption, thus transforming the information crisis of the elderly in China into a public health crisis.
- **The elderly with physical conditions or health issues may face physical challenges to using digital devices**, which in turn reduce their digital adoption and prevent them from fully participating in many common daily activities that have shifted online.
 - For example, many elderly often struggle with reduced reactivity, making it harder for them to keep up with fast-paced technology such as platforms that use notifications with time limit.

- *Many elderly with physical impairments* also face challenges in accessing web pages or use social media to keep in touch with their social networks. For example, 9% of seniors at the age of 75 or over have severe visual impairments, and 18% have severe hearing limitations in the EU (Eurostat, 2017). In the U.S, statistics show that 23% of older adults indicated that they have a physical or health condition that makes reading difficult or challenging. All these may present challenges to internet use *if the interface designs of websites are not inclusive with fonts and layout designs tailored to support usability by the elderly suffering from glaucoma or cataracts*. In the absence of extra attention and efforts at developing inclusive technological designs for this vulnerable group, it will culminate into a lower quality of life for them, more so for countries with a large ageing population.

B) Arguments against the statement

- There are **mitigating factors such as courses and initiatives to bridge the digital skill gaps and place easy-to-use resources** in the hands of the elderly communities (in the form of policies, support from the community like employers, social agencies). These initiatives ensure that the elderly **are not excluded and can enjoy the benefits of technology** even as we continue to digitalise.
- For example, improving the digital literacy of the elderly will enable them to move in tandem with the rapidly changing digital landscape and gain access to the many services and conveniences that have adopted digitalization to improve productivity and competitiveness.
- This is evident in launch of the Senior Go Digital initiative in May 2020 by IMDA Singapore, comprising one-on-one help and small group learning sessions conducted at more than 30 SG Digital community hubs island wide to help seniors pick up skills such as using smartphones to communicate online and access government digital services.
- To further support seniors in their digital learning, IMDA and SG Digital Office (SDO) will be introducing learning journeys such e-Payment Learning Journeys for seniors to help them learn how to use e-payments, or use commercial apps such as the FairPrice app to make purchases in NTUC FairPrice stores via live demonstrations and hands on experiences. These skills ensure that the elderly remain updated in the use of technology and can adapt to the growing digitalization of everyday services, such as hawker stalls adopting e-payment capabilities, to become active members of the information and knowledge society
- In addition, IMDA's Mobile Access for Seniors scheme for low income seniors, was rolled out to complement the Seniors Go Digital programme to ensure that the elderly are not disadvantaged by costs in the new setting. The scheme has benefited more than 800 low income seniors with smartphones and data plans.
- The digital age has **supported the aging process, more so for those who are more technologically savvy.**

(i) Tapping on the emerging smart technologies can help the elderly **stay independent**. Their day-to-day life can become easier by removing obstacles or automating household tasks that they find increasingly difficult to manage on their own as they age. We now have a seemingly endless list of smart home systems and devices such as automated and scheduled lighting, motorized window shades, motion sensor lights, security cameras, smart thermostat, robotic vacuums... to create a home that is easier, more enjoyable and safe to live in. Such aging-in-place technology has allowed the elderly to **maintain the daily life they have long enjoyed**. Additionally, smart personal devices such as smart watches provide access to apps to help the elderly with health management, socialisation, managing finances, household oversight and emergency response. Such technologies ensure that the elderly stay safe even when they are living alone and remain connected with the family and a broader community.

(ii) At the societal level, smart technologies **can improve the management and delivery of health and social care services to the elderly, especially during the Covid-19 pandemic**. Technological advances allow caregivers outside the house to monitor and provide support remotely. For example, the rise of telemedicine adoption in healthcare systems has connected the elderly patients with their healthcare providers virtually when the pandemic ruptured face-to-face visits to hospitals. Transitioning to video visits for elderly patients with the appropriate technology and capability has provided much more information on the status of patient's health and allowed communication with and monitoring by healthcare providers when compared to telephone visits. This can provide better health outcomes, allowing the elderly to maintain functional independence throughout the old age, a process known as healthy ageing. Such digital health technologies for healthy ageing are expected to mitigate the socio-economic effects of population ageing and improve the quality of life of older people.

- **With digital inclusion**, the elderly **can actively contribute** to the digital economy as a result of becoming **more digitally literate and active, changing the misconception of the elderly as being vulnerable to becoming valuable assets of society**.
- For example, the 'Silver Surfer' project in Luxembourg enlists senior citizens, specifically trained in Internet security, to instruct other older persons to safely and securely use digital technology. Besides helping to increase digital literacy among older adults, it also promotes volunteering and active participation of older persons in society and encourages lifelong learning. Creating lifelong participation of the elderly through digital technology can enable them to have a more active and longer productive life than ever before, thus positively impacting their well-being and quality of life after retirement.

